

Indigenous rangers are critical to Australia's ability to maintain an early detection system for exotic pests and diseases in remote coastal areas across the north. Increasing over time, current services provided by rangers include participating in animal, plant and aquatic health surveys, insect trapping/surveillance, plant host mapping, collection and destruction of biosecurity risk material and biosecurity awareness activities in remote communities, utilising their unique skills and abilities.

To further support the biosecurity work of Indigenous rangers, capability building grants have been made available to ranger groups who have existing biosecurity fee-for-service arrangements with the department.

Initially, the Ranger Capability Building Grants program ran for 3 years from 2020–21 to 2022–23, building on the existing capability of Indigenous rangers and were delivered by the department's Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Program.

Following the success of those initial rounds, a third round was made available in 2024 and the grant length extended to two years.

Program objective

The grant program will enable ranger organisations with existing biosecurity fee-for-service arrangements to undertake capability building activities, purchase equipment and undertake training to further enhance the capacity of rangers to conduct biosecurity surveillance and response work.

Intended program outcomes

The intended outcomes of the grant program are:

- Increased capacity of Indigenous Rangers to undertake current and future biosecurity fee-for-service activities for the department.
- Increased skills and capability of Indigenous Rangers to enhance their career pathways.
- Improved work health and safety of the work undertaken by Indigenous Rangers in remote areas.

Examples of the types of grant activities that may be supported by the department are:

- Capability building initiatives including ranger exchanges and conferences/leadership development programs.
- Capability building and work health and safety training.
- Purchase of capability building equipment or materials used in the course of fee-for-service work such as field equipment and small assets, IT and safety equipment.

Applications for Round 1 closed on 8 April 2021.

26 applications were received from Indigenous ranger organisations in northern Australia.

An assessment panel including a representative from the National Indigenous Australians Agency met in July 2021 to assess applications. 22 applications were approved for funding from October 2021 totalling \$1.1 million (see full recipient list below).

Examples of grant activities funded include:

- undertaking ranger training including coxswain, remote first aid, conservation and ecosystem management, remote 4WD and remote pilot licence (drone) training
- purchase of IT and other equipment including iPads, laptops, cameras and GPS units to allow rangers to capture and transmit to biosecurity data in the field
- equipping rangers with emerging technologies to enhance their field capability such as underwater drones and thermal cameras
- purchase of ATVs, UTVs and associated equipment to improve ranger capacity to access country to undertake biosecurity surveillance
- enhancing ranger safety by purchasing safety equipment such as satellite phones, life jackets, UHF radios and helmets
- regional ranger forums to provide the opportunity for rangers to improve work practices through targeted mentoring, training and skills exchange and valuable engagement with NAQS scientists and other government agencies
- ranger exchanges on country to facilitate ranger groups with less experience in undertaking biosecurity activities learning from high performing groups

Recipient	Town	Funding	
		State (GST inclusive)	
Larrakia Nation Aboriginal Corporation	Nightcliff	NT	14,400
Kowanyama Aboriginal Shire Council	Kowanyama	Qld	82,909
Dhimurru Aboriginal Corporation	Nhulunbuy	NT	51,394
Gunggandji Aboriginal Corporation RNTBC	Yarrabah	Qld	44,573
Wellesley Island Land Sea Social Economic Development Pty Ltd	Mornington Island	Qld	19,462
Tiwi Resources Pty Ltd	Tiwi	NT	37,952
Bawinanga Aboriginal Corporation	Maningrida	NT	35,292
Yuku-Baja-Muliku Landowner and Reserves Limited	Cooktown	Qld	42,341
Marthakal Homelands and Resource Centre Aboriginal Corporation	Galliwin'ku	NT	13,830
Dambimangari Aboriginal Corporation	Derby	WA	19,312
Jabalbina Yalanji Aboriginal Corporation RNTBC	Mossman	Qld	31,928
Mapoon Aboriginal Shire Council	Mapoon	Qld	49,796
South Cape York Catchments Inc.	Cooktown	Qld	23,100

Kuuku Ya'u Aboriginal Corporation RNTBC	Lockhart	Qld	56,460
Northern Land Council	Darwin	NT	281,164
Kimberley Land Council Aboriginal Corporation	Broome	WA	58,000
Thamarrurr Development Corporation Limited	Wadeye Community	NT	10,040
Deewin Kirim Aboriginal Corporation	Peppimenarti	NT	31,571
Gumatj Corporation Limited	Gunyangara	NT	32,755
Mandubarra Aboriginal Land and Sea Incorporated	Innisfail	Qld	4,842
Wunambal Gaambera Aboriginal Corporation	Wyndham	WA	30,282
Djunbunji Limited	East Trinity	Qld	55140

Applications for Round 2 closed on 8 February 2023.

20 applications were received from Indigenous ranger organisations in northern Australia.

An assessment panel including a representative from the National Indigenous Australians Agency met in March 2023 to assess applications. 15 applications were approved for funding in June 2023 totalling \$759,430 (see full recipient list below). Grant agreements and funding commence August 2023.

Examples of grant activities funded include:

- undertaking ranger training including remote first aid, conservation and ecosystem management, coxswain, remote 4WD and remote pilot licence (drone) training
- purchase of IT and other equipment including iPads, laptops, cameras and GPS units to allow rangers to capture and transmit biosecurity data in the field
- equipping rangers with emerging technologies to enhance their field capability such as electric side by side vehicles and underwater drones
- purchase of ATVs, UTVs and associated equipment and training to improve ranger capacity to access country to undertake biosecurity surveillance
- enhancing ranger safety by purchasing safety equipment such as safety helmets, hydration packs, PPE, chemical safety equipment and UHF radios
- leadership training to support emerging Indigenous leaders to develop skills to strengthen their ability to engage with and educate their communities.

Grantee Name	Recommended Funding Amount (inc GST)
Arafura Swamp Rangers Aboriginal Corporation	\$110,220.84
Carpentaria Land Council Aboriginal Corporation	\$63,701.74
Dambimangari Aboriginal Corporation	\$31,730.00
Larrakia Nation Aboriginal Corporation	\$37,718.47
Milingimbi & Outstation Progress Resource Association Incorporated	\$91,836.95

Napranum Aboriginal Shire Council	\$37,873.00
Northern Peninsula Area Shire Council	\$11,635.00
Abriculture Pty Ltd	\$42,579.00
Jabalbina Yalanji Aboriginal Corporation RNTBC	\$3,619.00
Laynhapuy Homelands Aboriginal Corporation	\$147,707.68
Mimal Land Management Aboriginal Corporation	\$42,995.00
South Cape York Catchments Incorporated	\$10,388.00
Thamarrurr Development Corporation Ltd	\$30,547.95
Tiwi Resources Pty Ltd	\$68,609.53
Wunambal Gaambera Aboriginal Corporation	\$28,268.00
	\$759,430.16

Applications for Round 3 closed in October 2024.

32 applications were received from Indigenous ranger organisations in northern Australia.

A Selection Advisory Panel including a representative from the National Indigenous Australians Agency met in November and December 2024 to assess applications. 30 applications were approved for funding in March 2025 totalling \$2,007,029 (see full recipient list below). Grant agreements and funding commence May 2025.

Examples of grant activities funded include:

- Purchase of thermal drones to enable effective monitoring, surveillance and data capture and mapping capability with built in flight-planning software
- Purchase of lockable storage for essential equipment such as ATVs, workshop materials, equipment and community engagement materials relating to biosecurity activities where the organisation lacks a base for their operations
- Purchase and installation of off-grid power (solar) for ranger outstation to improve rangers capability to undertake biosecurity activities around this site for extended periods
- Purchase of an UTV and trailer to transport the UTV to enable access to greater areas and more rugged terrain not accessible by 4WD for biosecurity surveillance
- Attendance at the Women's Environmental Leadership program for women rangers to support a recently developed Women's Ranger Strategy (2023) which reflects training needs and maps out how to support women rangers in their roles, providing employment pathways and staff retention
- Purchase of pig trapping equipment to trap pigs for surveillance and postmortem training, accredited drone training and minor works to upgrade a washdown facility at a ranger base.

Grantee name	Recommended Funding Amount (inc GST)
Aak Puul Ngantam Ltd	\$111,743

Queensland	
Goondoi Arts Aboriginal Corporation	
Queensland	\$67,066
Jabalbina Yalanji Aboriginal Corporation	
RNTBC	\$44,160
Queensland	
Mandubarra Aboriginal Land and Sea	
Incorporated	\$103,266
Queensland	
Mapoon Aboriginal Shire Council	
Queensland	\$85,148
South Cape York Catchments Inc.	
Queensland	\$34,515
Thamarrurr Development Corporation Ltd	
Northern Territory	\$110,133
Tiwi Resources Pty Ltd	
Northern Territory	\$59,382
Walalakoo Aboriginal Corporation	
Western Australia	\$35,111
Wuthathi Aboriginal Corporation	
Queensland	\$72,690
Yamatji Marlpa Aboriginal Corporation	
Western Australia	\$38,898
Arafura Swamp Rangers Aboriginal	
	\$129,875

Corporation	
Northern Territory	
Carpentaria Land Council Aboriginal Corporation	
Queensland	\$143,839
Dambimangari Aboriginal Corporation	
Western Australia	\$102,972
Dawul Wuru Aboriginal Corporation	
Queensland	\$14,198
Dhimurru Aboriginal Corporation	
Northern Territory	\$49,950
Gong-Dal Aboriginal Corporation	
Northern Territory	\$94,858
Gunggandji Aboriginal Corporation RNTBC	
Queensland	\$27,256
Hopevale Congress Aboriginal Corporation	
RNTBC	\$100,165
Queensland	
Karajarri Traditional Lands Association	
Western Australia	\$75,543
Kimberley Land Council	
Western Australia	\$99,957
Kowanyama Aboriginal Shire Council	
Queensland	\$7,668
Kuuku Ya'u Aboriginal Corporation RNTBC	
	\$103,553

Queensland	
Marthakal Homelands and Resource Centre Aboriginal Corporation	\$7,196
Northern Territory	
Milingimbi Outstations Progress Resource Aboriginal Corporation	\$106,425
Northern Territory	
Wellesley Islands Land and Sea Economic Development Pty Ltd	\$72,626
Queensland	
Wilinggin Aboriginal Corporation	\$12,779
Western Australia	
Yanunijarra Aboriginal Corporation	\$48,263
Western Australia	
Wunambal Gaambera Aboriginal Corporation	\$10,769
Western Australia	
Yuku Baja Muliku Landowner and Reserves Ltd	\$37,025
Queensland	

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/australia/northern-biosecurity/ranger-capability-grants>